



Making a point: “There’s a lot more excitement and fun in team events like this, especially with faster formats,” says Arjun Erigaisi. RAFAL OLEKSIWICZ/FIDE

The sheer scale of the event — more than 50 teams played Rapid and Blitz over the course of five days — would have been enough to rattle anyone’s nerves. But as with most teams, MGD1’s players drew strength and calm from one another, building strong chemistry in no time.

“I think most of us being Indians helped,” said Arjun. “Anton and Stavroula were also super friendly and nice. We tried to be in good spirits and have some fun together.”

According to Arjun, this was one of the factors that made the tournament particularly enjoyable and refreshing. “There’s a lot more excitement and fun in team events like this, especially with faster formats. Even if you lose, it’s still exciting and intense to watch your teammates fight on after your own game is over.”

“I had a really bad Day 2, but the team did a fantastic job of ensuring it didn’t affect the overall result. Some of our wins on the final day, including mine, were quite crucial.” A couple of



Superb show: Atharva Tayade, playing on the recreational board, stole the show with a sensational run of 11 straight wins. RAFAL OLEKSIWICZ/FIDE

them came in the final round against Malcolm’s Mates, with Arjun defeating English GM Luke McShane and Pranav beating Ivan Saric from Croatia.

“I played a risky opening, and it was a complicated position. But I calculated well in the end,” said Pranav, adding that Srinath’s presence was critical. “In important rounds, we were well supported by him. He told us to give our best and just enjoy the game.”

Having captained the team since the tournament’s inaugural edition, Srinath knows a thing or two about the Indian players, which made the task of assigning boards relatively straightforward.

“Having Arjun on Board 1 was an obvious choice as he was the strongest player we had,” said the captain. “Hari (Pentala), with his vast experience and incredibly solid game, rarely loses. He’s accustomed to playing on Board 2, so that was a natural fit. Anton, with his solidity and experience, slotted perfectly on the next one, from where he offered a lot of flexibility.”

For the lower boards — where the most decisive games occur — Srinath opted for the youthful aggression of Leon and Pranav.

But it was Atharva, playing on the recreational board, who stole the show with a sensational run of 11 straight wins. According to FIDE tournament rules, the ‘recreational player’ must be someone who has never achieved an ELO rating of over 2000 in any format, the aim of which is to promote grassroots talent on the world stage.

Arjun and MGD1’s founders, Sreekar Channapragada and Manu Gurtu, agreed that the youngster’s performance was the high point of the team’s campaign. “He had an incredible score and we couldn’t have won it without his brilliant performance,” said Arjun.

Sreekar went further: “Being a good player and living up to that reputation are two different things. His temperament shows he’s going to do well in life.”

Atharva, meanwhile, found the team setting both enjoyable and